It could have come up at any point – probably should have sooner, by sheer statistical probability. But then again, they could have just as easily never *really* talked about it.

Steve, Bucky and Tony watch with waning alertness as the people they rescued leave the bodega. The small shop had held up as well as they hoped it would; sheltering several civilians during their fight against a former SWAT-member who was more than a little unamused at the Avenger's efforts to rid him of his stockpile of incredibly deadly alien tech. His suspiciously glowing storage unit had been discovered by accident late at night, prompting this early-morning mission.

From their arrival at the scene to now, it has been just two hours and still, all three of them are pretty exhausted if only slightly battered. Their opponent sits very well-shackled on the curb, slumped down and surrounded by several members of the Avengers' support forces. His posture quickly changes when he sees Bucky looking at him, attempting an assertive facial expression while squaring his shoulders, which just makes Bucky roll his eyes and glance at Steve. The two shake their heads almost imperceptibly. Had they been on their own, Bucky would have made a joke about the, in his opinion, annoying fucker with the god complex and embarrassing sense of self-importance. But he bites back the comment, unconsciously shifting his weight to the right, a little further away from Tony.

The last person to limp from the bodega is a kid, probably just of age, cursing in the vague direction of the now shackled man who had attacked him not an hour earlier.

"…fucking asshole super villain looser, twisting my knee like that…" he almost shouts as he passes by Steve, Tony and Bucky. "…but I'll still make it to the playoffs, and he can suck my dick right into next week…" the teen continues his tirade as he walks out of earshot.

"Don't let Cap hear that next time, boy," Tony calls after at him, grinning at Bucky as if he expects a laugh but is instead met with a confused and slightly irritated expression.

"Why?"

"You know how Captain America gets about language," Tony explains with a small shrug, one-sided and with a casualness that can only stem from an unfounded certainty in the underlying assumption. Bucky narrows his eyes and turns towards Steve who acts disinterested, busily typing an update on the mission for Sam on his phone.

"What are you talking about? Steve used to swear so much, our neighbors complained that their children would be in better company among sailors than in our stairwell," Bucky responds while he continues to stare at Steve, tilting his head as if he were figuring out a

difficult calculation. Little by little, Steve's hunch over his screen becomes more pronounced and he firmly presses his lips together.

"Well, it's not just the cursing, is it. Ol' Capsicle might be okay with the occasional cussword but the sexual insinuation? He really is way to pure for that kind of thing," Tony asserts confidently, only adding to Bucky's befuddlement.

"You're joking, right?"

"I mean, kinda, yeah, but also, he's not exactly known for *not* being a prude."

"A prude?!"

This has Bucky's eyes darting from Steve to Tony and back again, wide with disbelief. Finally, Steve looks up and steadily returns Bucky's gaze, his head angled slightly upwards and jaws clenched. For a few moments, they stay like this, Steve's expression unchanging while a whole host of emotions flit over Bucky's face.

The tension is palpable and Tony starts to fidget with the touchpad on his arm, having decided it's no use to try to decipher whatever's going on.

"Let's get going, people, we're meeting at Avenger's HQ in ten," Nat interrupts Steve and Bucky's silent exchange, her voice filtering in through the tiny intercoms in their ears. "Also, Steve might not be a prude, but I'm pretty sure he protects his virtue as well as he does his collection of vintage dishware. Shouldn't you of all people know that, Barnes? He can't have been that different back then."

It takes another second for Bucky's resolve to crumble, but when it does, he nearly doubles over with laughter. The rich sound bounces off the brick walls around them and Steve can't stop his lips from curling ever so slightly, revealing the faintest hint of a smirk.

As soon as Bucky has calmed down to a gentle chuckle, Tony starts to walk in the direction of his tower, uncharacteristically quiet with confusion. The wrinkles around Steve's eyes are a bit deeper than usual, but he still manages to keep up his serious expression until Bucky gently knocks into him, nudging him with his shoulder.

"Stevie, you sly dog! You really made them believe all the Captain America propaganda Senator Brandt was so eager for you to memorize, huh?"

Very quickly, a grin darts across Steve's features just for Bucky to see, immediately vanishing as they step into the tower.

“What are you saying, Sarge? Steve secretly has an interesting side to him?” Tony asks, malicious curiosity mixing with his trademark snide tone that’s just a bit more mocking than usual, leaving sharp edges on his words. If there’s one thing Bucky doesn’t respond well to, it’s someone ordering him around; but people underestimating Steve comes in at a close second and so Bucky refuses to answer the question – as much as he wants to set the record straight.

Nat, Clint and Bruce join the three of them on their way to the conference room Sam is already waiting in. His left arm is still in a cast that has prevented him from all of his Falcon duties – and for once, everyone’s on the same page about that being a good thing. The mission that had left him with the fracture had rattled all of them, but he was definitely the worst off. When he had tried to get back out there while still dealing with the injury, Bruce did what he had to do and used Sam’s own mantra ‘rest is a part of recovery’ to get him to agree to some time off.

That, of course, does not prevent Sam from joining their debriefs and as much as Nat tells him he should stay home and relax, they all appreciate seeing him getting better and better.

“I hear we’re getting some behind the scenes intel on Steve’s virtue?” Sam greets his friends with an easy smile that shines brightly, getting Bucky and Clint to warmly mirror his expression.

“Well, it seems you have all been fooled so properly I’m not sure whether I should shatter your impression,” Bucky starts, promptly interrupted by Steve who looks at Bucky with his left eyebrow cocked.

“Best if you don’t, then.” His dry tone sounds almost genuinely disinterested – *almost*.

“I’m not sure what supposedly shocking tales you have in store for us. It’s not the forties anymore and we’re not scandalized by some girl showing her ankles to Steve – or to you, for that matter,” Tony says and turns his head in Bucky’s direction, only to be met with an amused huff.

Nat nods with a curious near-frown and adds: “Tony’s right, from all we know at least. Two weeks after the defrost, we pestered Steve into telling us about his first – and apparently last – time he had with some USO girl. And, as he himself likes to say, he doesn’t lie.” With a lopsided smirk, she sits down at the head of the table and lets her scrutinizing look roam over Steve’s face when he exchanges another glance with Bucky.

“Sure, everything he says is true. Doesn’t mean he doesn’t leave out some important details.”

Everyone's listening closely to Bucky's words; even Clint has his eyebrows raised, and Bruce puts his phone in his pocket as Bucky leans forward, all conspiratorially.

"When I tell you this man has perfected the art of lying by omission – I mean, you all fell for it hook, line and sinker. But-," Bucky begins when Maria Hill suddenly enters the room and everyone hurries to look as professional as possible.

"As much as I'd love to hear all about the escapades of a ninety-something from before or during World War II, I have better things to waste my time with. So, let's get on with the debrief."

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It's the first warm night of the year, so Bucky really should have guessed Steve wouldn't be home right now. But he's still a bit surprised when he finds himself alone in the apartment.

Bucky's date had abandoned him when she found out he had spent an evening and half a night with her best friend just last week. Not feeling like flirting with anyone else there, he had left the dance hall on his own, like he rarely does these days. With only half an hour to midnight and a busy week at the docks ahead of him, he had headed for the shabby little place Steve and him share.

Now he's standing in the sparsely furnished kitchen and randomly picks up a can of beans, flipping it in his hands as he looks out the window. After a few minutes, he decides to sit on the fire escape and plucks a cigarette from his coat. It's well-rolled and expensive-smelling, Bucky notes as he smiles to himself triumphantly. He had swiped it earlier that day from a man in a stiffly pressed three-piece suit who looked just a little too smug for Bucky's liking.

The smoke curls around the metal grate above him and he stares into the endless deep, dark blue of the sky, only slightly tinged by the smoke from the city's factories. This time of the year is perfect, not yet too hot and no longer too cold; he doesn't have to worry about Steve getting sick. It's a relief after he'd spent all spring listening for the telltale rattle of Steve's lungs, still anxious from when Steve coughed and wheezed all of December. The thought of Steve safely strolling through the warm night comforts Bucky and, at the same time, stubbornly tugs at him in a way he can't quite place but has gotten familiar with over the last few months – years, if he was honest with himself. With a heavy sigh, he leans back and closes his eyes just for a second, asking himself what the hell Steve is doing out this late.

He wakes up with a start at a rattling of the lock not an hour later. With a sleepy groan, he stretches as his joints protest at the sudden shift from the less-than-ideal position he had slumped into.

"Whoa!" Steve's voice comes from inside the apartment, sounding almost guilty and reminding Bucky of the time their neighbor caught them spitting cherry pits onto his stoop. "That you, Buck?"

"Yup," he replies as he slides through the window into their apartment, squinting at Steve to search for new bruises or scratches he will put ice on and scold his friend for. Instead, Bucky finds Steve grinning widely as if he can't help it, looking more relaxed than he has all year and confident in a way that makes his blue eyes glint. For a second, they just stand here, Steve leaning against the doorframe and Bucky running his fingers through his dark hair.

"What have you been up to that has you smirking like nobody's business, Stevie?"

The question hangs between them, heavy in a way Bucky hadn't expected and after a moment, he furrows his brow. Steve's expression grows tense as he crosses his arms and stands upright, a determined quality in his stance.

"I went with some of the guys I met last year at that free drawing class down by the center. They, um-" Nervousness flickers over his face and Bucky's frown deepens. "Basically, they showed me around some places men meet."

"Places men meet." Bucky repeats flatly, not understanding a word of what his friend is trying to say, making Steve grimace before attempting to explain.

"You know – men who aren't into dancing, at least not at the dancehalls with- with women. Men who meet each other, instead. There's spots they- you know-" Steve stutters and finally, realization dawns on Bucky's face.

"Oh, you mean like what they always said about Mr. Richardson and that friend of his, the one he always said he'd visit in Montana every other month?"

"Yeah, like that."

"And you went there?"

"Sure did."

“And?” Bucky’s tone is neutral, not shocked or appalled, the inflection just the same as if he were asking about the groceries. The casual curiosity calms Steve somewhat, but his palms are still damp with sweat.

“And I- spent the evening with someone.”

“Did you… do anything?”

“Yeah,” Steve admits, fidgeting with the hem of his shirt at the side where it’s not properly tucked into his trousers.

“So, you had fun?” Bucky asks, turning to get two cups and a bottle of lukewarm beer he proceeds to open with the handle of their one and only steak knife.

“I did. What- What’s the beer for?”

“Come on, we gotta celebrate a little bit, at least. It’s not every night Steve Rogers has his first time,” Bucky smirks and hands one of the cups to his friend who laughs as the tension bleeds out of his posture.

“Jerk,” Steve mutters without any heat. The crinkling around his eyes reveals just how glad he is at Bucky’s reaction. With his heart beating faster than it should, Bucky raises his beer as if to deliver a toast.

“Punk.”

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The meeting lasts for over an hour, but that doesn’t mean anyone’s forgotten what they were talking about. They all stay put after Hill has left, heads turning in Bucky’s direction. Only Steve starts to get up, casual in a way that’s definitely an act and Tony quickly breaks the moment of silence to stop him.

“Cap, where do you think you’re going? We have serious business to discuss here.”

Steve sits back down again, rolling his eyes and crossing his arms which doesn’t quite work to hide the amused smile tugging at the corners of his mouth.

“Lying by omission how, Barnes? We asked him and he said his first time was with a girl on his stage tour,” Nat states as Clint chuckles at her tone, serious as if they were negotiating a hostage situation.

Realization dawns on Bucky’s face and he grins at Steve who shrugs almost shyly, admitting to whatever’s glinting in his friend’s eyes. For a moment, they just look at each other while everyone else sits with anticipation before Bucky laughs again and turns towards them.

“His first time with a girl, he said?”

Nat is the only one who seems to be able to glean anything from Bucky’s words as her frown slowly softens but she decides to keep her thoughts to herself.

“Yup and not a whole lot of time to get into skirt chasing after that. Plus, from what my dad told me, that was more your wheelhouse, wasn’t it?” Tony asks, clearly trying to figure out the puzzle sitting in front of him.

“Well, first of all, yes. I was quite the ladies’ man, let’s not forget that. But even I didn’t have Steve’s rate of success if it came to, well-“ Bucky glances at Steve again, making sure he doesn’t object to him telling everyone and is met with a small, acquiescent smile. “-if the metric we’re going by is how regularly someone gets their dick sucked.”

A quiet, amused huff escapes Steve’s lips as everyone else just gapes at Bucky and him.

“But you said, he didn’t lie- Wait, are you telling us that Steve -“

“-was very popular with New York’s young men of a certain persuasion? I certainly am.” Bucky finishes Bruce’s sentence, leaving him with an equal parts surprised and impressed facial expression. Nat smirks, leaning back and sizing up her friend she just learned a lot more about while Clint and Tony exchange glances.

“Anyone got a problem with me being gay?” Steve interjects in a neutral voice and is immediately met with a slew of muttered phrases – ‘of course not’ and ‘happy for you’ and ‘you could have told us anytime’.

“So yeah, he left the ladies to me – not a lot of skirts in the places he went,” Bucky concludes.

“Not none though,” Steve concedes with a sly grin. “Liked those, too, on occasion – lot easier to do a quick little number in an alley when you don’t have to get rid of a guy’s trousers.”

“Oh my god. I can’t believe I just heard Captain America endorse skirts because they allow for prime blowjob access,” Sam almost stutters, sounding thoroughly flustered to both Bucky’s and Steve’s satisfaction.

“If only you knew. There were guys on the docks who made sure to be extra nice to me because they didn’t want to spoil their chances to have a good time with Steve on the weekend.”

“Weekdays, too, sometimes, at least in the summer. Too cold in the parks to do anything outside the rest of the year,” Steve adds. For a fraction of a second, Bucky’s smile freezes and something wistful flickers in his eyes before he returns to his amused demeanor. Not even Steve notices it, too busy folding his arms back over his chest and leaning into the sleek but cushy office chair.

“So what, everyone in Brooklyn knew about Steve’s apparently prolific mouth-throat-coordination?” Clint asks curiously.

“Hands, too,” Steve mutters and revels in the small gasp from Tony while Bucky squares his shoulders, pondering how to answer the question for a moment.

“No, he mostly kept away from Brooklyn – you wouldn’t want to get caught on your knees by your neighbors. Wasn’t all that safe back then and I had enough trouble keeping this punk out of trouble before he discovered all the fun he could have with other guys. But some of the men I worked with went to the same places Steve did, and we bumped into one of them at Coney Island. After that, he figured it might be a good idea to treat me with a little more kindness. Guess he must have let it slip to one or two other guys; I sometimes even got lunch out of it.”

“Okay, that’s cute and also depressing, very sorry about the last century and all the homophobia back then, but I want details – what did you do? At what age did you start? How did you meet the guys? Weren’t there, like, raids and undercover cops and shit?” Tony turns to Steve as he goes into his interrogation mode, specifically engineered to press whoever finds himself as the subject of it for every bit of information.

“Obviously, homophobia’s not just a problem of the last century since none of you even considered me being with anyone else than women,” Steve shoots back with a measured glance. “And I don’t feel like answering your onslaught of intrusive questions, thank you very much.”

“Wait, but didn’t Agent Carter literally shoot at you? I always assumed that was a lover’s spat or something,” Nat wonders to Steve’s surprise.

“How do you know about that?”

“I can read a file long after it’s been made unavailable to amateurs such as yourself,” she smirks.

“Impressive. You’re a little off, though – Peggy was angry because she caught me kissing another woman after I had already told her I didn’t swing that way.”

“I had to step in and convince her he wasn’t lying. She was mostly mad he lied to her when she had been so open with her feelings; not so much jealous, she never was, but she felt betrayed. God knows, she would have been too good for your sorry ass, anyway,” Bucky adds and turns to Steve. Rolling his eyes at Bucky’s wide grin, Steve can’t help but smile at the memories. His expression turns soft and fond for a moment before Clint cuts in.

“So Bucky, you’re basically just always there to correct whoever assumes Steve is straight and doesn’t get any? First Carter, now us?”

“Oh my god, no wonder you did everything to get him back, Steve – he’s the one to tell people Captain America actually *fucks*,” Sam laughs affably, earning himself a friendly headshake from Steve even as he starts to get up.

“Yeah, yeah, I think this is quite enough for now.”

Bucky hums in agreement and follows him out of the room. They don’t talk, just casually bump against each other when they turn a corner, their arms brushing.

As soon as they close the door to Steve’s apartment in the tower, they start to laugh and collapse onto the wide couch in the living room, where they stay for several minutes. The vibrant noise fills the air, making the room lighter as both of them shake uncontrollably until Steve’s limbs are splayed all across one half of the couch. Bucky is curled up close to the middle, arms tucked to his chest when he chuckles:

“Oh my god, I can’t believe they really thought you were a blushing virgin.” He shakes his head, still in disbelief. “Steven Grant Rogers, sexless man from the last century. Damn, they really don’t know shit about you.”

“To their defense, there was no one around to tell them otherwise, Buck,” Steve acknowledges, a hint of sadness creeping into as his voice he glances at Bucky who is still rubbing his eyes. “Also, it’s not that they don’t know me at all. Nat and Sam are actual friends, you know that. Bruce would be, too, if he was around more and Clint is fun to hang out with.”

Neither one of them comments on the fact Tony's missing from that list. They've already spent enough evenings ranting about him, leaving for a stroll in the city where JARVIS wouldn't hear them blowing off steam about their billionaire teammate. There's just something about smug, rich men neither one of them can get over, especially when this particular man makes it a point to insert as many pop culture references as possible neither one of them gets into every single conversation.

Bucky takes the brief silence as an opportunity to muster the courage to ask something he's been wondering for a while, willing it to sound casual:

"I take it you haven't gone back to your philandering ways then, if it never came up with any of them?"

"I mean, no. You haven't, either," Steve replies, letting the implicit question float comfortably between them.

"No. Can't really say I miss it, either. It was fun at the time, and I wouldn't have wanted it any other way. But the shit from the war and afterwards really knocked my desire to fuck around out of me." Bucky admits, wondering why he hadn't thought about it until now. "Guess I already found out enough," he adds with a huff, trying to insert some levity into his words, but Steve sighs heavily anyways.

"I know what you mean. Back then, I was chasing the thrill and the casual joy of it – and now, life is plenty thrilling, whether I like it or not."

They stare at the ceiling and Steve slouches deeper into the soft cushions until their shoulders touch. Neither one of them moves to change that.

"So you don't miss any of them, none of the guys you had a good time with?" Bucky asks after a lull in the conversation and feels Steve tense up next to him. A thieving grin spreads across his face at the certain knowledge that there is, in fact, an answer to the question Steve will do his best not to give. The prospect of learning which man had made the faint blush appear on Steve's cheeks just now is too enticing to Bucky to leave it alone.

"Who is it?"

"Bucky…"

"Come on, I want the gossip! Tell me what guy you were just thinking about because I can tell you immediately had someone in mind. He must around a hundred by now or close to it, think of that," Bucky says before he can stop himself, wincing when he realizes that

there is, in fact, a much more depressing option for what might have happened to the man. Steve just sighs again, glancing over with a flat look in his eyes as Bucky raises his hands apologetically.

“Okay, that one’s on me. I’ll ask you another time, and we’ll just ignore how depressingly many years have passed.”

When Steve doesn’t react to that beyond a noncommittal shrug, Bucky gets up to make them some hot chocolate. He might be klutz, he tells himself, but not one to leave his best friend sadly slumped on a sofa without at least something sweet to console him. As he walks into the kitchen, Steve’s eyes follow him closely, his expression unreadable and serious.

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Steve does his best to close his eyes and just enjoy the feeling of the man’s tongue on his cock, expertly moving around its head and curling just the right way. The rough hands dig into Steve’s hips as the man moves closer, taking in more of him with each second. Finally, he swallows him down, his throat tight around Steve who does his best not to make a sound and not to look down into the icy blue eyes he feels searing into him. His fingers are playing with the guy’s dark hair, just a bit less curly than Bucky’s and – no, no, no, this is not the moment to think about that, Steve decides with conviction, even as he comes right then and there, pleasure tightening and easing through the muscles in his body in quick succession, leaving every inch of his skin tingling.

When the man comes up again, Steve notices how he’s just a little taller than Bucky, his smooth chin glistening with spit he wipes away. Doing his best not to think about another chin, one with a pretty cleft right in the middle, Steve scrambles to get his own pants back into place while he already fumbles at the button of the admittedly very handsome man’s trousers.

He’d caught Steve’s eye immediately from across the room and, to Steve’s surprise, taken the same interest in him. Normally, Steve knew better but tonight, he let himself be carried away with it. The stranger had introduced himself as Tommy and soon, Steve found himself with the rough brick wall digging into his shoulder blades and with Tommy’s smart mouth on him.

Finally succeeding in slipping Tommy’s boxers down just far enough, Steve gets on his knees and starts to suck Tommy off. He knows how to do this, has done it more often than

he cares to count and yet, every time, he finds himself newly amazed at just how much he enjoys it.

Tonight might be a little different in a lot of ways, but not in his enthusiasm for this; if anything, Steve's ill advised choice to go with someone that reminds him of his best friend makes him more desperate. He takes Tommy down quicker and further than usual, spurned on by how familiar he looks, at least at first glance. The impression doesn't hold up to scrutiny but that doesn't stop Steve from squinting upwards as the man's breathing becomes ragged. Not even a minute later, he comes and Steve stays where he is, slowing his movement until the last shudder of Tommy's orgasm has run through him. Only then does Steve get up, swaying almost and smirking with a shrewdness he's felt so often after going down on a man, but can't quite get a hold of tonight.

"That was... something," his acquaintance smiles softly, pulling him closer and kissing him once more. Tommy's lips are gentle and warm, moving lazily at first and becoming more determined with every lingering touch of their tongues. "Stevie," he groans into the kiss and Steve suddenly freezes. His insides painfully twist at the sound of the nickname and he pulls back, wiping his mouth with the back of his hand.

"Sorry, I didn't mean to- are you okay?" Tommy asks and Steve manages to nod, taking another second to collect himself enough to respond.

"Yeah, sorry, all good. Just remembered how late it is. This was fun. See you around?" Steve's voice sounds robotic and hoarse in a way that has nothing to do with his throat.

"Sure. Have a good night and- thank you, I really enjoyed spending time with you."

The man gives Steve another smile, earnest and a little sad, before walking away and rounding a corner. It's just enough time; tears start to streak Steve's cheeks as soon as the dark swoop of hair has disappeared into the night.

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Of course, the day Steve's lying by omission is revealed is a Thursday – the one day all Avengers have a three-course meal together, at least those who can make it. It's to no one's surprise that the moment Steve and Bucky arrive at the common area, the conversation between their teammates comes to an abrupt halt.

"Yeah, yeah, big news, Captain America's gay – can we get on with it, now?" Steve rolls his eyes and Bucky gently nudges him in an effort to tamper his grumpiness.

“Oh, it’s not about you being into men. It’s about you being into *a lot of* men and very successfully so, if what I’ve been hearing is correct,” Pepper chimes in, smiling brightly as if she had just won the lottery. She wouldn’t need the money, of course, but Steve would still be happy for her, he thinks to himself. Being in a relationship with Tony Stark has to be unimaginably draining and she therefore deserves every single little joy in Steve’s opinion.

Grumbling with a mixture of annoyance and amiability, Steve takes a seat across from Sam and Nat who sport mischievous grins and exchange glances with Bucky who’s already fidgeting with his cutlery.

The three course meal is delicious as always and the conversation drifts from topic to topic, never failing to return to Steve’s sex life but staying on a pleasantly light level – until desert.

“But James, you found out at some point, obviously – how’d you take it? I mean, you were, presumably, a man of your time with certain opinions and perspectives on things…” Bruce lets his voice trail off with the uncomfortable implication, looking at Bucky with a mix of caution and honest curiosity. Something in the room shifts, slightly but noticeably, as all the other conversations around them quickly die down.

“Well, he’s my best friend. I wasn’t much of a square, I think, and he already knew about the things I was up to. You gotta remember, sex outside of marriage was still somewhat taboo, even if it didn’t involve two men. That type of thing could ruin a woman’s reputation and a man’s as well, at least if it happened often enough. So I was kinda discreet and it just made sense for Steve to hide his sex life a whole lot better,” Bucky responds carefully while feigning an ease he doesn’t feel. He dreads the kinds of questions that might follow.

“Bit more of a risk, though, with the two of you sharing an apartment, right?” Clint adds and Bucky nods slowly while Steve looks down at his plate. He starts to individually collect every single crumb left by the crust of the cheesecake. No matter how delicious the desert, it takes Sam a single glance to understand it as the nervous habit it is and he hurries to switch the topic.

“What did you pay for your place, by the way? The current prices must seem beyond ridiculous to you guys.”

“Oh my god, I can still barely believe how much things cost, rent and everything else as well. The first time I went to a grocery store after I got my memories back, I thought I was having an aneurism. How the fuck do people pay several – several! – dollars for a few vegetables?” Bucky exclaims, more than glad to take the opening.

For a few minutes, everyone at the table who has struggled with a tight budget rants about inflation and price gauging and the general audacity of landlords. When Tony tries to join in by complaining about increasing production costs and steel prices, they shut him down quickly, much to his dismay. Annoyed with his exclusion from the conversation, Tony turns to Steve, ready to mellow his own frustration by making Steve just a little more uncomfortable.

“And you never wanted to jump the Sarge’s bones, what with his winning charm and all?”

Before Steve has the time to do as much as clear his throat, Bucky steps in: “He never came onto me, Tony, and it’s pretty telling that you’d assume he would. Also, I’m bisexual, so I don’t get spooked by the idea of a man finding me attractive – in case you were trying to freak me out or whatever. Now, cut it out and get us some of that expensive whiskey of yours as penance for your nosy bullshit.”

Bucky raises an eyebrow at him and Tony just mutters something about dangerous bisexual murder machines no longer invited to dinner while obligingly shuffling towards his cabinet, hunched over with the knowledge that he took it a bridge too far.

The obviously toothless remark sends a jolt of relief through Bucky’s tense limbs, and he does his best to hide the shift in his posture by clearing his throat and crossing his arms. Steve might be the best at it, but over the years, Bucky has picked up a thing or two about lying by omission.

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“What exactly has possessed your scrawny ass that you’d even try to sneak out? Can I remind you that it’s almost November and you’ve been only back on your feet for less than a week!” Bucky shouts when he catches Steve with his hand on the door handle. It’s Friday night and by the clothes he’s wearing – not to speak of the guilty look on this face – Bucky know exactly where Steve is headed.

“Come on. It’s not even that cold yet and I think I deserve a little fun after spending ten days with a fever,” Steve grumbles, already close to giving up on his plans by the sound of it.

“Going out in this biting cold will have you back to sweating your soul out again in no time, and you know it.” With a frown, Steve kicks his shoes in the corner next to the door and crosses his arms.

This is Bucky's chance, he realizes, and feels just wild enough to take it. "If you need your dick sucked that bad, I'll do it," he offers with a reckless tone to his voice, tilting his head a little too intently for his own liking while his heart threatens to beat out of his chest.

Steve just gapes at him, needing a moment to collect himself, and then shrugs off his chunky coat. He takes another long look, his eyes roaming over Bucky's face that's red with a deepening blush, contradicting his deliberately casual expression. Finally, Steve nods, seemingly more to himself than at Bucky's words but that's all it takes for Bucky to walk up to him, gently crowd him against the wall and drop to his knees.

"Buck- you know you don't have to do this? You're right, it's too cold and I won't go out," Steve manages to whisper, swallowing hard at the enticing sight in front of him.

"Eh – I wanna know what all the fuss is about, anyway. You with me?" Bucky asks, quickly switching from his usual cocky demeanor to something more earnest, and god, if that doesn't get Steve going. When he nods to answer Bucky, it's with a lot more determination than before.

"Good. Because this-" Bucky reaches out and smooths his hands over Steve's crotch, feeling him starting to get hard. "-doesn't feel like someone who just wants to stay home and sketch without getting off first."

Steve does his best not to moan at the feel of Bucky's palm and the hushed words coming out of his mouth, all too aware of the neighbors that regularly complain about all sorts of noises they shouldn't be able to hear.

He screws his eyes shut as Bucky rucks up his shirt, undoes his pants and pulls them down with swift movements that feel almost practiced, like he had spent time thinking about doing this. The thought makes Steve wonder but before he can do as much as to properly line up the words to ask Bucky about it, Bucky's fingertips start to skirt along Steve's inner thighs, exploring the sensitive skin while resting his forehead on Steve's hipbone. Steve can feel Bucky's hot breath falling onto the fabric of his boxers and he wants nothing more than to take them off, to feel more, to have Bucky closer. He's getting hard, faster than he'd want to admit and he half expects Bucky to tease him for it, but he's preoccupied with gently touching Steve's lower stomach and tracing the trail of hair on it, several shades darker than the blond strand falling into Steve's line of sight.

Carefully, Bucky stretches the waistband over Steve's cock and gets his boxers out of the way. He hesitates for a moment before almost shyly brushing his lips against Steve's right hip, kissing him lightly, and making his way to Steve's navel. With his right hand, he finally takes Steve's cock, stroking him gently in a way that has Steve huff out a breath, suppressing the urge to moan loudly.

“This feel good?” Steve hears Bucky whisper and all he can do is nod again, look down and swallow hard at the sight of these blue eyes, heavy lidded and bright as the morning sun at the same time. Bucky smiles sweetly with none of his usual bravado before his lips part to take the head of Steve’s cock into his mouth. Everything in Steve narrows down, blanking out the rest of the world and focusing on the Bucky’s wet, warm mouth and the tentative swipes of his tongue. For a second, he pulls off and spits in his hand to stroke the shaft of Steve’s cock as he sinks his mouth back on him. Steve bites the inside of his cheek to not make any noise, the feeling too intense for him to trust his self-control when Bucky speeds up little by little. Almost instinctively, his fingers start to card through Bucky’s hair, soft and a bit damp in the back of his neck where he has started to sweat ever so slightly.

It doesn’t take long before everything feels unstoppably good and Steve helplessly glances down once more, overwhelmed by what he sees and barely has time to mutter Bucky’s name as a warning. But Bucky doesn’t move away, just looks back at Steve who comes as his breath hitches, trembling at the overwhelming feeling of it. He lets his head fall back against the wall, staring towards the ceiling and steadying his legs when Bucky takes his mouth off of him and stands up.

There’s a moment of silence between them, Bucky leaning against the wall next to Steve, turned towards him and his eyes roaming over his face, his neck, his shoulders. Steve knows that hunger in his eyes, familiar with it from seeing it in so many other men, but he had never dared to dream Bucky looking at him like that.

With a swift movement, Steve gets his pants back up, buttoning them but not bothering with the zipper, and steps closer to Bucky who doesn’t flinch. Instead, his heavy-lidded gaze drifts to Steve’s lips. That’s enough for Steve and he closes the distance between them, kissing Bucky who immediately pulls him into his arms, greedy lips parting easily for Steve’s tongue to lick into his mouth. Bucky’s cock is hard under the rough fabric of his pants, rubbing against Steve’s still sensitive skin, and they both move against each other, desperate and wanting. With his eyebrows raised in a question, Steve pulls back and slides his hand down from Bucky’s chest over his stomach to the height of his belt loops. Bucky nods quickly in response before pulling Steve closer again and kissing him harder when Steve’s fingers reach his crotch.

Just a moment later, Steve slides his soft hand in Bucky’s boxer and now it’s Bucky’s turn to avoid moaning as best he can. The gentle but firm strokes make him pant quicker, careful not to make too much noise but unable to entirely stop himself. Steve kisses his cheek, his throat, the spot behind his earlobe and picks up the pace, touching Bucky in ways he had dreamed of many times before, even if he’d never admit to it.

Bucky comes with Steve's lips on his own, his legs close to shaking and sweat collecting on his forehead. For a moment, neither one of them says anything, eyes firmly locked onto each other, sharing hot breaths, Steve's hand still down Bucky's pants, now slick with his come. It takes them longer than either one of them is used to to start moving again, Steve eventually washing his hands in the sink and Bucky collecting his towel for a shower. Before he closes the door to their tiny bathroom, he leans against the frame and watches Steve settle onto the couch until their eyes meet and he turns away.

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The good thing about pressuring Tony into giving them the good booze is that everyone who isn't a supersoldier or part-Hulk is at least a little drunk by the time Bucky and Steve leave – so no one notices the tension in Steve's shoulders as they walk out of the room.

Bucky sees it immediately, though. He squints at his friend, obvious in a way Steve can't overlook if not on purpose, and waits for him to say something. But Steve stays silent, eyes fixed in front of him as if he had developed a sudden interest in the speckless grey floor. With a sigh, Bucky decides to let him stew in his thoughts until they're in their living room.

"Cat got your tongue, Rogers?"

Steve rolls his eyes at the overly formal nickname and is met with a challenging stare. Bucky's unwillingness to let it slide is radiating unmistakably from his determined stance when he leans against the doorframe of the kitchen. After a moment, Steve gives in and takes a deep breath.

"I just didn't know you were bisexual."

With an incredulous huff, Bucky's eyes widen before he barks out a laugh.

"Steve, are you fucking joking?"

"No?"

"You, of all people, *know* I'm into men. And I thought I was the one with memory issues," Bucky says, a mixture of amusement and indignation dancing through his words.

“We never talked about it, and I thought you might have tried it out of curiosity but found out you weren’t into that sort of thing.” Steve’s voice sounds strained and he avoids looking at Bucky.

“Wow. You gotta think I’m pretty dense if you assumed I hadn’t figured it out by, I don’t know, the tenth time.” Annoyance colors Bucky’s words and Steve furrows his brow, his expression soft with concern.

“When you came back, I wasn’t sure you even remembered. And then I figured it might make you uncomfortable if I brought it up and you had no idea we ever- got up to that sort of thing with each other,” Steve admits and rubs his hand over his face, exhaustion and nervousness washing over him.

“No, I’m not uncomfortable. Are you?” Bucky responds quickly, his voice now as tense as Steve’s shoulders.

“No, no, not at all. Just- when you said that at dinner, I assumed I was probably right to never mention it to you.”

“Would you have wanted me to tell them-“

“God, no,” Steve interrupts him and shakes his head. “Bad enough they constantly try to set me up on dates – I’m sure Nat will find every queer guy in the agency for me to hook up with now. I really don’t want them to meddle with- you know.”

“Yeah, neither do I.” Another considering look at Steve’s hunched form, then Bucky yawns deliberately and takes a step towards his bedroom. “Better get some sleep, Stevie, before your undoubtedly busy schedule of dates with hot field agents and charming bureaucrats starts tomorrow. Nat’s probably working on it right this second.”

Steve groans at Bucky’s wink and shakes his head. This is going to be exhausting, he thinks, but can’t help smiling at his friend’s mischievous expression.

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By the time Steve leaves the bathroom, Bucky has already climbed on the fire escape and plays with the matchbook in his left hand. If it weren’t for Steve’s asthma, he’d probably smoke a cigarette, Steve realizes and wonders whether he usually lights up after having sex. Bucky’s open shirt falls over his shoulders and the soft skin on his defined chest is still a little damp from the washcloth he cleaned himself with. His legs are splayed open,

not all that different from earlier that night when Steve was crouching in front of the sofa, his head busily moving between Bucky's thighs.

He smiles at Steve lazily, his expression still tender with afterglow. It's been a while since they've last done this. The winter had long passed and with it, the weekends Steve stayed home when he wasn't invited to one of his artsy friends or to the home of one of the men he had grown to enjoy during the summer. Both spring and autumn had been warmer than the years before and Steve had found himself almost wishing for a colder Saturday, just to see whether Bucky would scold him for risking his health, pull him closer, kiss him with hungry lips. He feels calmer now, the knowledge that nothing has fundamentally changed comfortably settling in his stomach. After a moment of contemplation, Steve stretches to reach for his sketchbook on the cupboard and sits down, grabbing the pencil on the desk. Soon, he's hunched over the paper, squinting at Bucky's form every now and then.

It sends a subtle shiver down Bucky's spine to see Steve like this, relaxed and focused at the same time, sketching with so much care, sketching him. The process is breathtaking, never failing to capture Bucky's interest: The pencil is loosely held in Steve's long fingers, his hand flies over the paper, leaving lines behind as if by accident and yet, with every brush of the lead tip, another detail comes in clearer and clearer. Steve bites on the inside of his lower lip every now and then, tilting his head slightly and furrowing his brow before he returns to the easy flow that seems so natural to him.

If he wasn't so busy feeling warm and fond at the sight, Bucky would envy Steve in his ability to just sink into the joy of drawing, seemingly forgetting everything else around him and creating something so beautiful with it. The way things are, Bucky could spend all day watching him, staying in place for Steve to sketch him and letting the ache in his chest grow deep and deeper.

But for as much as they've had sex with each other, Bucky can't go over there and kiss Steve, softly and slowly, just because he wants to. Maybe he'll try to, Bucky thinks and knows that he won't. He might offer Steve a blowjob later, an excuse to get close to him again and indulge in touching him, kissing him, feeling him, tasting him. It won't be enough, it never is, but god, he wouldn't miss it for the world.

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Bucky screws his eyes shut, hissing sharply when Steve assesses the wound on his right arm. The knife had hit him just underneath the shoulder, cutting through muscle and hitting the bone underneath. His entire body throbs with pain and cold sweat is running down his back.

Steve tries to get Bucky's attention by talking to him, telling him that the woman who had thrown the knife had been caught by Sam, flown out of the rubble to be arrested.

But Bucky's eyes stay glassy and nothing in his expression indicates he hears a single word Steve says. Desperation seeps into Steve's voice and he reaches out to carefully wrap his arm around Bucky, holding him closer in an attempt to calm him down.

It seems to work to some degree as Bucky's breath slows down bit by bit, but his posture stays rigid and unyielding. This is enough for Steve to swiftly tap a finger against his earpiece; worried gaze fixed on Bucky and waiting for the small electronic noise indicating the intercom's activation. Three sharp bleeps ring through his ears, warning him about the device's low battery. Steve does his best not to swear, committed to not upset Bucky any further with bad news.

"Sam, how quickly can you get us out of here?" he asks as soon as the line is established.

"Fifteen minutes, maybe ten. How badly is he hurt?" Sam responds with audible concern.

"Not sure. Some damage to the bone, a gnarly wound, but it should heal in a day or two. He's pretty out of it, though."

Steve furrows his brow when he takes it all in, Bucky's unnaturally stiff posture and the hazy look in his eyes.

"It's his arm, Steve. Pretty sure loosing the other one was traumatic as fuck. Try to talk to him, tell him where he is, distract him when he comes back to you."

Of course, he should have realized it earlier, Steve thinks and clenches his jaws, frustrated at himself. He quickly tells Sam about the dwindling battery in his earpiece and shuts down all of its functions except for the GPS tracker. Finally, he turns to Bucky whose face is sickly pale and framed by dark hair sticking to the sweaty skin.

"Bucky, can you hear me?" Steve asks, leaning closer and trying for eye contact – to no avail.

"Your name is James Buchanan Barnes and we're here together and it's the future, but there's still no flying cars. We live together in Tony's stupid tower, he's Howard's kid and you really don't like him. Yesterday, you made a casserole for the two of us and I screamed when you grabbed the dish from the oven without a glove because I didn't realize you did it with your metal hand. You-"

“You don’t like him, either,” Bucky stammers, blinking rapidly before shivering and finally looking at Steve.

“What?”

“Tony. You don’t like him either.”

“Yeah, I don’t,” Steve admits, relief shaking his voice as he presses his face into the crook of Bucky’s neck. “You’re back.”

“I’m back,” Bucky answers, slowly and deliberately, breathing through the pain of his injury.

“Sam said to distract you, so I’m just gonna talk, keep on talking until they pick us up and we can get you some pain meds. Do you remember the summer I got beaten up so badly you almost punched that kid’s nose so hard he- No, that’s not a calming story, sorry, I’m really bad at this,” Steve rambles and runs his right hand over Bucky’s back while using the other to gently cup his face. The look in Bucky’s eyes clears up more, little by little, as Steve presses their foreheads together and keeps talking, jumping from memory to memory.

“…and then, Ms. Hollingsworth accused you of stealing her newspaper which you obviously didn’t do, you were to busy sneaking into the apartment above hers where Dana lived – you dated her for two months or something, probably your longest relationship. Oh no, wait, there was the summer you went with Maria, she was so pretty with her flowy dresses, and you always blushed when you talked about her. I think you were pretty gone on her, you never even talked about having sex with her which you always did with all of the other girls, you dog. The number of evenings I spent listening to you recounting just about everything you ever did – that only stopped when I could threaten you to tell you all of my business in return. Guess I really found the only way to shut you up when-“

“Tell me about him.”

Bucky’s voice cuts through Steve’s stream of words, low and quiet. The color is slowly returning to his face, and he even raises his eyebrows, albeit just by the smallest bit.

“Huh?” Steve asks genuinely confused. With another sigh, Bucky clears his throat and his gaze drifts towards the sky.

“Tell me about him. The guy you were thinking about. The one you miss.”

When Steve doesn't respond, Bucky explains: "I asked you and you didn't answer, we were on your couch, and you got all tense and silent at the question."

"Oh," is all Steve manages to say, realization and apprehension ghosting over his face.

Annoyed with his unwillingness to answer, Bucky rolls his eyes and lightly shoves against Steve's shoulder with his left hand. The movement is clumsy and unfocussed, but a far cry from the complete numbness minutes earlier.

"Who is it? I wanna know, wanna hear you talk about him," Bucky mumbles as he closes his eyes and waits for Steve's words to hit him, revealing who exactly had the stupid luck to make Steve blush after all that time. He's prepared for this to be painful, hoping for it to distract him from the memories of a saw screeching close to his body, of leather restraints digging into his skin.

"It's you," Steve says, simply and seriously, and glances at Bucky, meeting his confused, wide eyes.

"What?"

"You, Buck. It's you. I miss you."

"But… You have me back." Bucky's voice is thick with emotion as he shakes his head. "It can't be me."

"I'm sorry," Steve whispers dejectedly, slumps together and starts to move away from Bucky.

"No. You're sorry? Steve, don't go. Stay here. Stay with me, please," Bucky pleads, desperation entering his voice when his breath hitches and tears start to roll over his cheeks.

Something in Steve breaks as he scoots back to him, closing the gap between their bodies again and clenching his jaw in an attempt to not feel the void beneath him that had opened with Bucky's rejection. At least he doesn't want him to leave. At least he can be here by his side.

"Steve, why did you never say anything?"

"Would it have changed anything?"

“Hell yeah, it would have. I thought I was going mad with how bad I wanted you all the time, how much I missed you when you were out or I was or both of us had dates.”

Now it’s Steve’s turn to shake his head in confusion, opening his mouth to ask a thousand questions when they hear the sharp noise of metal wings cutting through the air as Sam approaches.

“Bucky, you seem better than I expected,” Sam starts as he lands before he stops for a second, furrowing his brow as he realizes that something is off, just not in the way he expected. “You okay, guys?”

Grunting in response, Steve gets up and takes Bucky with him, his arm wrapped around his waist to support his weight. Bucky goes easily, his metal hand gripping Steve’s shoulder for balance.

“I thought I’d lift you just that bit over there, you’ll be able to walk – Hulk cleared a path from the rubble before Bruce came back. Steve, can you properly hold onto me?”

The next half of an hour passes in a haze. They make it away from the site and Bucky gets a dose of tranquilizers administered that would have knocked out a small elephant. On him, it works just well enough to lessen the sharp sting of pain when a medic removes the knife and cleans the wound.

Steve’s hand lingers on his neck the whole time, their eyes meeting again and again, exchanging unsure glances.

“Guys, I’d give you a lift but we gotta hurry with the clean-up, there’s some damage to the power grid we need to fix. I can unlock that car over there if you’re safe to drive, Steve?” Sams suggests and not a minute later, they sit in comfortably soft car seats in decidedly less comfortable silence.

“I’m not even your type, Steve,” Bucky finally manages to say as the buildings rush past the window.

“What are you talking about?”

“You didn’t go for guys like me. Back then.”

Steve balks at the claim with a deep frown.

“How the fuck would you know that?”

“Remember Ronnie?”

“Yeah, I remember Ronnie. What about him?” Steve huffs impatiently.

“He talked to me about you once – he was so drunk he could barely stand upright. And he told me that he’d be jealous of me, getting to live with you, if he didn’t know for sure that we weren’t up to anything. I kept probing him on it and, well, he said that the one thing everyone down there knew about you is that you never went with darkhaired men with like, blue or green eyes.”

For a moment, it’s eerily quiet in the car. Then, Steve sighs before straightening his back with determination.

“He wasn’t wrong. But- It wasn’t because you’re not my type, Buck. It- Do you remember when I came home with puffy eyes that one time and you bugged me about what was wrong for, like, half a month?”

“And then you finally told me that you were on a date with someone called Tommy? Yeah, I fucking remember. You never explained what happened but I’m sure Tommy deserves to get his face kicked him, whatever he did to make you cry like that. It was at least a week before you didn’t move like a spooked horse around the apartment anymore.”

Harsh protectiveness bleeds through Bucky’s words and he grits his teeth at the memory of Steve coming home, distraught and avoiding him like the he might burn at his touch.

Steve grimaces, guilt and embarrassment visibly washing over his face.

“Tommy didn’t to anything wrong, I told you then and I’m telling you now. The thing was – I always avoided the men that, well- men that reminded me of you. I figured there was nothing to be gained from that and it might make it harder to see you after that when I already- you know. And then I met Tommy that night, he- let’s just say I didn’t stick to that rule of mine. He had real nice hair, brown and thick, and- Anyways, we had a good time and everything was okay and then he called me Stevie and I- I just-“ Steve lets his last sentence trail off as Bucky turns his head and stares at him.

“Oh my fucking god. You could have had me anytime, Steve, if you had just said something.”

It’s the softness of Bucky’s voice that makes Steve’s breath hitch. There’s so much Steve wants to say to him, wants to ask him, wants to pull him close, but of course, that’s when

they arrive back at the tower. They stare at each other for a long moment before Steve slowly puts his hand on the car door handle, hesitating before he steps out.

Another four hours later, they finally get to leave the last debrief session of the night with a whole bag full of painkillers. When Steve opens the door to his apartment, he doesn't even bother to pull off his boots before he lets himself fall on the couch.

"Bucky, we really need to talk about all of this, but I don't think I'll manage another coherent sentence unless I can sleep, like, twelve hours beforehand."

"Sounds about right," Bucky groans and leans on the backrest of the couch with his forearms. With jerky movements, he gets out of his shoes and then stands in the middle of the living room, looking a little lost.

"Wanna come here?" an already half-asleep Steve asks, spreading his arms wide as an invitation. He sighs happily when Bucky carefully nestles himself against Steve's chest.

They sleep for fourteen and a half hours, deep and dreamless like neither of them ever does.

Steve wakes up at a content noise from Bucky, muffled against his collarbone and takes a moment to look at his messy dark hair, to feel Bucky's face mushed against his shirt, to hear his soft breaths. He must be at least partially awake, but his body still weighs heavy on Steve, even as he starts to move ever so slightly.

"Mhmmmm," Bucky hums, lifting his head by the tiniest bit to nuzzle into the crook of Steve's neck. With a wave of fondness crashing in his chest, Steve gently presses his lips on the top of Bucky's head and feels Bucky's smile on his skin.

In an attempt to get even closer to Steve, Bucky rearranges his right arm, immediately regretting the movement and hissing from the pain dully throbbing up his shoulder and down his ribcage.

"That goddamn knife," Bucky murmurs and pulls back, sitting down next to Steve and slowly circling his right shoulder blade to assess the situation. "Can you check the wound for me and dress it afterwards? I want it cleaned once more, I have absolutely no interest in getting an infection no matter how quickly my immune system deals with it."

There's a worried look on Steve's face as he gets the painkillers and a glass of water which Bucky gladly accepts. Another half a minute of rummaging around the bathroom and Steve sits down next to Bucky with the first aid kit.

Steve's voice is soft and low when he unravels the bandages and dabs disinfectant on the exposed tissue steadily knitting itself back together, explaining every step he does in an effort to make Bucky as comfortable as possible. It works to a degree, but Bucky still has to look away, dreading the sight of the damage to his arm, even if it is temporary. After a few minutes, Steve has expertly fixed new bandages onto the injury and starts to gather the different supplies from the first aid kit together.

The sweat that has collected on Bucky's scalp is cool and sits uncomfortably at the roots of his hair. With a sigh, he gets up and gingerly walks towards the bathroom.

"I'm gonna wash up. Jesus fucking Christ, I really hate people messing with my arm," Bucky mutters and closes the door behind him, just to immediately open it again. "I didn't mean you, by the way, I mean whoever threw the knife. Thanks for helping me out, Stevie."

The nickname makes both of them freeze for a moment, looking just past each other with the sudden reminder that there's something they very much need to talk about.

Not before he gets rid of the layer of sweat covering his body, though, Bucky decides and pulls the door shut.

Steve busies himself by tidying the living room, throwing away the bloodied bandages and rearranging the cushions. The sound of water running in the sink trickles through the bathroom door as Steve finally unties his shoelaces and gets his boots off, scrunching his nose at the realization that he has been wearing the same socks for almost 48 hours. He'll need a proper shower, he decides and ignores the faint voice in the back of his head telling him off for evading the conversation with Bucky.

With a change of clothes in hand, he waits for Bucky to get out of the bathroom and is struck by the sight of his bare chest as the door opens.

"Wait, I still need to brush my teeth, then it's all yours – wanna join?" Bucky asks easily and lightly, his posture revealing both the relief of having cleaned up and of the painkillers doing their job.

"Um, yeah," is all Steve manages to reply to that. He shuffles through the door, putting his things on the dresser while Bucky throws on a tank top and sweatpants in his room. With the towel he had wrapped around his waist now thrown over his metal shoulder, Bucky crosses the hallway to a hunched over Steve busily brushing his teeth.

Neither one of them says anything while they stand there, their eyes meeting ever so often in the mirror and the sounds of plastic bristles on teeth filling the air. There's an intimate normalcy to the situation and it makes the blood rush through Steve's ears so loudly he's certain Bucky has to know.

Thanks to his supercharged hearing, Bucky can actually hear the heavy thumping of Steve's heart; it makes him smirk before he spits the toothpaste in the sink, rinses his mouth and closes the door behind him.

Not ten minutes later, Steve returns to the living room, standing by the couch like a man who doesn't quite know what to do with himself as Bucky putters around in the kitchen.

"So?" Steve asks quietly, trusting Bucky to pick up the question through the noise of the coffeemaker.

"Well," Bucky says as he emerges from the kitchen, leaning against the doorframe.

For a moment, they just stare at each other, unfamiliar uncertainty hanging between them.

"You miss me, you said," Bucky states, nervously tapping the knuckles of his finger against the wood of the door.

"I do. You wanted me, you said," Steve replies and swallows hard, still unsure whether it could be true.

"Drop the past tense," Bucky corrects him with a small smile and his eyes fixed on Steve's, unwilling to give into his impulse to look down.

A sharp breath shudders through Steve's broad frame as he struggles for words.

"But- Do you even like me like this?" His voice sounds strangled as he gestures at himself.

"Like that?"

"Like this. We never- You never touched me after the serum."

With two long strides, Bucky closes the distance between them, stopping just short of bumping into Steve. He can feel the warmth radiating off of Steve's body, smell the citrusy shampoo they both used and can't help but to think of the smooth, soft texture of Steve's skin.

“It wasn’t because I didn’t want to. I just- I couldn’t be who I was before. Before the war, it came to me so easily; I knew exactly how close I could get to you before it would break me open. But after they strapped me to that table, everything already felt so fragile all the time. And I couldn’t risk you finding out, couldn’t risk losing you,” Bucky admits with his eyes closed, the words to raw for him to look at Steve.

After a moment of taking all of that in, Steve reaches out and pulls him closer, resting his forehead against Bucky’s and reveling in the sensation of their bodies softly pressed against each other.

“Bucky,” is all Steve can say as he lifts his hand trace the faint stubble on Bucky’s jaw. He responds by wrapping his metal arm around Steve and carefully moving the injured one until his fingers card through the short hair on the back of Steve’s head.

Bit by bit, they inch closer together until their lips brush. Bucky gasps at the sensation, warm and gentle and so soft, and tilts his head a little to the side to properly kiss Steve. He’s met with an equal mix of gentleness and fervor, Steve running his hands up and down sides while parting his lips so that their tongues can touch, hot and wet and still incredibly soft. Their breathing picks up pace as their bodies move against each other almost instinctively. Bucky lets his left hand slip under the fabric of Steve’s shirt, feeling his muscles shift as Steve leans into the touch and quietly moans.

“I take it you don’t mind the metal, then?” Bucky smiles with relief from a concern he didn’t realize he had, pulling back for a moment and facing a slightly frowning Steve.

The notion that Steve could reject any part of Bucky offends him deeply; there is nothing Steve would rather feel than every single inch of Bucky’s body against his own. But he recognizes the self-consciousness in Bucky’s words and decides to keep his response only lightly scolding, wanting show Bucky how utterly ludicrous he finds the question.

“No, I don’t mind your *arm*, Buck.”

Bucky pulls him closer and kisses him deeply, almost frantically as if Steve might vanish any second. He tastes like toothpaste and desperation and home, and Steve grabs his hips and grinds against Bucky who responds with a surprised moan. Both of them get harder at the sensation and Bucky’s hand wanders from Steve’s collarbones over one of his nipples to his abs and further down. The smooth metal grazes the sensitive skin just above the waistband of his pants, making Steve’s breath hitch.

“What do you want, Stevie? We could be like we were back then,” Bucky whispers against Steve’s lips and is a bit surprised when Steve shakes his head.

“No, Bucky, I want more.”

The response makes Bucky smirk, leaning back slightly to properly look at Steve.

“You want ‘more’? Were the others right and you’re too pure now to call it fucking?”

A bright red blush blooms on Steve’s cheeks who quickly clears his throat, looking at the floor.

“I mean, I want that as well, but I wasn’t talking about that.” His cheeks stay burning hot when Bucky fondly laughs at him.

“You might not be virgin, Steve, but you sure blush like one. Maybe your friends weren’t all that far off,” Bucky grins and kisses Steve quickly, unwilling to go without the touch of his lips but pulling back to let him finish his thought.

Something serious and worried flickers in Steve’s eyes when he says: “I want more, Buck – I want to kiss you just like that sometimes, in passing or when you come back from the gym. I want to wrap my arms around you while you’re cooking. I want to sleep next to you whenever you want me to and hold you when a nightmare wakes you up. I want to nestle up to you when we watch a movie. I want to tell you that I love you, just because I want to. And because it’s true.”

The words fill Bucky with so much emotion he’s worried he might fall into pieces from the sheer strength of it. His smile is as bright as the morning sun when he cups Steve’s face in both his hands, moving carefully both for the sake of his injury and to avoid disrupting the tender moment.

“Steve, I have loved you for such a long time. You were the first thing that came back to me for a reason, you know. I want everything you just said, all of that and then some.”

Dizzy with bliss, Steve presses his forehead against Bucky’s before kissing him again, lightly and carefully. His fingers follow the curve of Bucky’s cheek downwards, dance over his pronounced jaw and land on the sensitive skin in the hollow of his throat where Steve rests his thumb as his hand caresses the side of Bucky’s neck.

Soon, the movements of Steve’s lips become demanding when Bucky slots one thigh between Steve’s legs, feeling his cock pressing into him, hard and hot with Steve grinding against him. The intensity makes Bucky almost lose his balance as he angles his body so that he can better chase the friction of Steve’s skin.

“You know I’m not gonna last long if we keep this up?” Steve breathes, breaking away for a second and suppressing a moan at the sight of Bucky with wet lips and hungry eyes. He grins in return and starts to build a steady rhythm with his hips, drawing little noises from Steve every time Bucky’s thigh presses into him.

“We have all the time in the world to go slow later, tomorrow, next week,” Bucky whispers in Steve’s ear, his voice rough with desire, and he gently bites Steve’s earlobe, only to let his mouth fall open with a desperate groan when Steve grabs a fistful of Bucky’s top to shove him even closer. They pick up the pace, their lips hovering above each other, just shy of touching as they share quickly panted breaths. Steve slips his hands under Bucky’s shirt and carefully digs his fingertips into the hot smooth skin, not too hard but firmly enough to make Bucky loudly moan.

The sound pushes Steve over the edge and his hips stutter as the orgasm tears through his body, the pleasure blanking out everything but the sensation of Bucky pressed against him. Bucky’s movements become just as erratic seconds later as he clutches Steve’s shoulders, letting himself fall deeper into the sensation pulsing through him.

It takes them several moments to catch their breath, kissing again and again with hot and unfocussed lips, smiles tugging at the corners of their mouths whenever they open their eyes to look at each other.

“I think I might need to change into a new pair of boxers,” Steve murmurs after a while of letting his hands idly roam over Bucky’s body.

“So do I, pal,” Bucky huffs and reluctantly drags himself from Steve’s embrace when his stomach growls embarrassingly loudly.

“Sounds like you might also need something to eat.”

“Sure do. Wanna wrap yourself around me while I fry some of leftover noodles?”

“That’s exactly what I want.”